condolences, telling him she wanted to give him a hug but didn't know if it would be appropriate. With the letter she included a gardenia, to plant in the son's memory.

A week later Mr. R appeared at our front door at Nott Cott. He handed Meg a thank-you note and gave her a tight hug.

I felt so proud of her, so regretful about my feud with Mr. R.

More, I felt regretful about my family feuding with my wife.

52.

We didn't want to wait. We both wanted to start a family straightaway. We were working crazy hours, our jobs were demanding, the timing wasn't ideal, but too bad. This had always been our main priority.

We worried about the stress of our daily lives, that it might prevent us getting pregnant. The toll was starting to be visible on Meg; she'd lost a great deal of weight in the last year, despite all the shepherd's pie. I'm eating more than ever, she reported—yet her weight kept dropping.

Friends recommended an ayurvedic doctor who'd helped them conceive. As I understood it, ayurvedic medicine sorted people into categories. I don't recall which category this doctor sorted Meg into, but she did confirm our suspicion that Meg's weight loss might be a barrier to conceiving.

Gain five pounds, the doctor promised, and you'll get pregnant.

So Meg ate, and ate, and soon put on the recommended five pounds, and we looked hopefully at the calendar.

Towards the end of summer 2018 we went to Scotland, the Castle of Mey, to spend a few days with Pa. The bond between Meg and Pa, always strong, grew even stronger during that weekend. One night, over pre-dinner cocktails, Fred Astaire playing in the background, it emerged that Meg shared a birthdate with Pa's favorite person: Gan-Gan.

August 4.

Amazing, Pa said with a smile.